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Dane County Sheriff's Office covers Flock cameras, looks toward finding new provider

ALPR technology 'imperative for effective public safety in rural communities,' Sheriff says

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Even as Dane County and some local municipalities have ended their contracts with Flock Safety for use of its automated license plate reader (ALPR) cameras and database, some are considering alternative systems.



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A covered Flock Safety camera is shown on June 8 on U.S. Highway 12/18 just west of State Highway 73 near Deerfield. The Dane County Sheriff's Office said it covered up the automated license plate reader (ALPR) cameras when Flock did not remove them by May 31, the date the county's contract with Flock expired.

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The Dane County Sheriff's Office's contract with Flock expired on May 31, after the County Board voted in April to end it.

The Sheriff's Office said in a news release that it then informed Flock Safety that all 26 of the county cameras needed to be removed by that date.

"When removal did not occur, the Sheriff's Office took steps to ensure the cameras were not in use and placed covers over them," the news release said.

"I look forward to moving ahead with a new ALPR company that can provide the public safety technology we need in our rural communities while maintaining control over the data collected," said Sheriff Calvin Barrett.

In a recent guest column in area newspapers, Barrett said he was encouraged that the Dane County Board's Public Protection and Judiciary Committee voted 7-1 to recommend redirecting the \$80,000 in funds from the canceled Flock contract.

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The resolution is a step toward allowing the Sheriff's Office to start a request-for-proposal process to obtain ALPR technology from a new provider, he said.

There are approximately 16 companies that offer advanced ALPR systems with robust privacy safeguards, reliable performance in rural environments, and proven track records in balancing public safety with individual rights," Barrett wrote.

Besides Dane County, the cities of Verona, Oshkosh, Monona, and Fitchburg have now ended or voted to let their contracts with Flock expire.

In addition, the McFarland Police Department announced in May it would not move forward with a plan to install Flock cameras, citing the decreasing number of cameras in the area as one reason.

“Once Dane County lost their funding for Flock, we lost about half of the potential camera network within Dane County,” said Police Chief Brian Redman, according to a news release from the village.

“I had to ask ‘Were we still going to get the return on our investment with that loss?’ With the network being chipped away, that wasn’t going to be the case.”

While some jurisdictions have indicated the possibility of using a different company’s license-plate reader system, they have not said whether they were coordinating with each other to choose the same provider in order to allow inquiries to draw from a broader number of cameras.

In the past few years, many south-central Wisconsin counties, cities, and villages have installed ALPR systems, which use cameras and software to automatically capture, analyze, and store license plate numbers, and often, additional identifying information from the backs of vehicles.

That information is processed, and when used as part of a network of data, can alert law enforcement to stolen or wanted vehicles, help them solve other crimes, or locate missing persons.

Atlanta-based Flock Safety calls itself the “largest public-private safety network” and says it is used by more than 5,000 law enforcement agencies in 49 states. Entities using Flock cameras can choose to share data with other agencies to aid searches that span multiple jurisdictions.

The Dane, Columbia, and Jefferson County Sheriff's offices, as well as the Cottage Grove, Marshall, Monona, Sun Prairie, and Waunakee police departments were all using Flock cameras at the start of the year, as were Jefferson, Lodi, Poynette, Watertown, and Whitewater. Lake Mills and McFarland police were going to get them this year.

Besides pushback against what some see as Big-Brother overtones and “surveillance creep” with the camera systems, there have also been concerns about whether U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) and other federal agencies can access Flock data from local communities.

Flock Safety said in a blog post that “ICE does not have direct access to Flock cameras, systems, or data, unless the agencies that control their data expressly and deliberately allow it.”

But while each local government agency or business that has a contract with Flock can decide which other agencies it will share its data with, it is possible one of those other agencies could in turn still share that data with a federal agent.

“We respect the board’s decision to end our relationship with Flock Safety, and we want the community to know we take their privacy concerns seriously,” said Sheriff Barrett in the news release.

MORE INFORMATION

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